



THIS IS THE UNIVERSE. BIG, ISN'T IT?

A MATTER OF LIFE AND DEATH / 1946

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Wartime fantasy

DIRECTORS

**Michel Powell,
Emeric Pressburger**

WRITERS

**Michel Powell,
Emeric Pressburger**

STARS

**David Niven, Kim Hunter,
Roger Livesey, Raymond
Massey, Marius Goring,
Katherine Byron**

BEFORE

1943 Powell and Pressburger's *The Life and Death of Colonel Blimp* is based on a British comic-strip character.

AFTER

1947 *Black Narcissus* is a psychological drama set in a convent in the Himalayas.

1960 Powell's dark thriller *Peeping Tom* is savaged by the critics. His career never recovers.

A *Matter of Life and Death* is the story of a young British bomber pilot, Peter Carter (David Niven), whose aircraft is damaged over the English Channel, leading him into an epic fight to live.

In the memorable opening sequence, the camera tracks across stars and distant galaxies. "This is the universe," a narrator informs us

amid the twinkling. "Big, isn't it?" Eventually, we home in on a view of Europe from space, then zoom into the interior of the bomber. The camera pans to reveal Peter sending a final radio message before he must jump without a parachute. He jumps... and to his and our surprise, wakes on a deserted beach.

Peter fights for his life

after surviving the crash. The movie plays with the possibility that heaven is a product of Peter's delirious mind.

